

The BJP is hoping to win over the middle class voter disenchanted by the poor quality of roads, garbage collection and unclean Yamuna

attended meeting in a park in a crowded colony in Dwarka, "they will take away your free schools, free medical treatment, free bus rides, free water, electricity. Don't you press the wrong button by mistake." The gathering at Dwarka is a mix of young first-time voters, middle-aged blue-collar workers, elderly residents and an overwhelming number of women wearing the 'Aam Aadmi' caps, all responding to him with measured enthusiasm and laughing at his jokes. Street-corner-style meetings like these are Kejriwal's forte. The party has long found them more effective than the BJP's mega rallies.

THE BJP'S COUNTERATTACK

The doubling down on freebies, though, has become the central election issue around which even the BJP, the AAP's main rival, seems to be fighting. It has led even Prime Minister Narendra Modi to assure that they won't be stopped if BJP comes to power. Addressing a rally in Northwest Delhi in early January, Modi, who coined the phrase *AAPda* (catastrophe) to describe Kejriwal's party, said: "Seeing their defeat in the Delhi election, they (AAP) have started spreading the lie that if the BJP comes, this would be stopped, that would be stopped. But I want to assure the people of Delhi that no schemes of people's welfare would be stopped in the BJP government... In schemes where *AAPda* people have looted people's money, those schemes would also be run with full honesty by putting honest people." In doing so, Modi is playing Kejriwal's game, feels Rahul Verma, head of Politics Initiative of the Centre for Policy Research (CPR). "The BJP had a chance to set the narrative by offering something beyond freebies. But between December

↘ MATCHING FREEBIE FOR FREEBIE: The BJP is announcing parallel welfare benefits while promising to improve the delivery mechanism for existing ones

↘ DEPLOYING RSS MACHINERY: RSS teams of five volunteers each are reaching out to voters, regularly meeting them in groups of 25. Its foot-soldiers on the ground are also striving to ensure that their supporters come out and vote on February 5

↘ HEEDING LOCAL OPINION: Local satraps like Ramvir Singh Bidhuri, Parvesh Verma, Bansuri Swaraj, Yogender Chandoliya and Manoj Tiwari have been given say in ticket distribution. RSS workers are also working overtime to appease rebels as well those unhappy with ticket distribution

↘ STEERING CLEAR OF POLARISING AGENDA: The BJP leadership is being careful not to push communal issues so that the Muslim vote does not get consolidated

↘ BANKING ON CONGRESS: The BJP is hoping that the rival national party will split the Muslim and the slum/Jhuggi Jhopri (JJ) cluster vote, which will work to its advantage